

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 229

Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1950-1961

Coverage Date: 1950-1961

Place Coverage: Nyae Nyae Region, Namibia And Botswana

Section Title(S)

The Homonymous Method of Applying Kin Terms to Consanguineous Kin and Affines

When the generational method of applying terms was described, we saw *!gun!a* applied m.s. and w.s. to males only. *Tūn* was the corresponding term applied to females. When the homonymous method is used, a female ego applies the term *!gun!a* (or rather its diminutive *!guma*) to a female named for her. That female reciprocates by calling her *!gun!a*.

553
[Naming](#)

601
[Kinship Terminology](#)

The terms applied to persons named for ego's spouse are also *!gun!a* (or *tūn!ga* w.s.) or *tūn*. The affinal terms *!hoa* and *tsau* for husband and wife are used only for ego's actual spouse. Persons named for the spouse, who is terminologically of ego's generation, have the generational terms applied to them that classify them with ego's generation and give them the joking relationship. The term *tūn* is applied to the wife of a male whom ego terms *!gun!a* (or *tūn!ga* w.s.). *Tūn!ga* is the term applied to the husband of a woman whom a female ego terms *!gun!a*. (In this situation, *!gun!a* is not used; in other words, it is not an alternate to *tūn!ga* here.)

553
[Naming](#)

601
[Kinship Terminology](#)

602
[Kin Relationships](#)

The term *!gun!a* has other applications. Ego applied it to the person *for whom he is named*, and also to anyone, related or not, who happens to have the same name as his, and to relatives *named for him*—with two exceptions: (a) Siblings. Although they are not named for each other, they frequently have the same name, being named for the same person. If ego and his sibling have the same name, the sibling terms are retained, taking precedence over the term *!gun!a*. (b) Primary affines. As I have mentioned, if the primary affine and ego happen to have the same name, or even in the unlikely situation of ego's being named for a man who became his primary affine, the term *!gun!a* would be dropped and the affinal term used. The same is true for a woman applying the

553
[Naming](#)

601
[Kinship Terminology](#)

term to the woman she is named for, to females named for her, or to females having the same name as hers.

(4) Other kin. I believe that the basis of the homonymous method is ego's classification of relatives by their names with himself and his spouse, his parents, offspring, and siblings, but classification by this method is not limited to these categories. Other kin as well are classified by their names. When some relative is named for another of ego's kin, ego applies the same term to him that he applied to the kinsman.

553

Naming

601

Kinship Terminology

Furthermore, ego continues to apply terms to relatives in the descending generation who are named for those whom he has classified by name. For example, he applies the term *tsu* to A because A was named for his (ego's) father; he continues to apply the term *tsu* to relatives who are named for A.

553

Naming

601

Kinship Terminology

(5) Affines. Consanguineous kin of ego's may be named for his primary 230 mary or secondary affines. Ego's son and ego's brother, for example, would in all probability name some of their children for their wives' parents or siblings. When one of the generational or sibling terms is used for the affine, ego uses that same term for the kin named for the affine. The exclusively affinal terms, as I said previously, are not used for kin. For kin named for ego's **tum*, / *utsu*, *n!unba*, or *n!untai*, for example, ego would use the generational term that corresponds in generation and joking status with the affinal term, namely, *tsu*, // *ga*, *!gun!a*, and *tũn*.

553

Naming

601

Kinship Terminology

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)